

Chapter 44-1

The mechanical voice continued to ramble on as usual.

[Due to the host using illegal means when obtaining luck points, such as exposing personal information, three luck points will be deducted this time. The host's current luck points are fifty-eight. (Emmm, for a moment I don't know whether you succeeded or failed. Forget it, since Little System has already found you, you should start the additional side quest!) The misfortune points are four. Please work hard to complete the additional tasks, host. Otherwise, next time, the host might receive punishment from the misfortune system.]

[PS: You know, Little System doesn't want to punish you. Another PS: Please stop self-exposing! If you continue like this, even immortals can't save you! Yet another PS: Little System advises you not to be OOC¹ anymore.]

[Forget it, you're already so OOC that Little System's advice is meaningless. Host, you must work hard! Accumulating such high luck points in less than a month is truly unprecedented talent. Little System is proud of you! Cheering for you! To send us scumbag women back to their happy old home², let's work hard together!]

[Oh right, are you busy right now?! Host, please work hard! According to detection, your target's emotions are currently unstable. Your misfortune points are continuously increasing. Eek! It's reached seven! Wuu wuu wuu, so scary. Host, you must keep going!]

This strange, cutesy mechanical voice had just finished when another serious mechanical voice sounded.

[Ding dong! Detection shows that the host's misfortune points have accumulated to sixteen, triggering level two punishment. Punishment content: heart pain. Duration: five minutes.]

[Misfortune point accumulation list as follows:

Silence angering Xu Qingzhu: 2

Ignoring Xu Qingzhu: 5

Deceiving Xu Qingzhu: 6

Making Xu Qingzhu cry: 6

Total: 19

PS: All interpretation rights belong to the misfortune system. If you have differing opinions, please... hold them back.]

The strange mechanical voice ended.

Liang Shi felt as if something had struck her heart hard. The physical pain instantly pulled her consciousness back.

She clutched her chest and collapsed onto the sofa. The moment she turned her face, she discovered Xu Qingzhu was crying.

Liang Shi: "....."

So all the misfortune points were added while the system was talking to her, when her expression was vacant and she couldn't respond to Xu Qingzhu?

So this system... was it sick?

She didn't even have time to think, didn't have time to curse this damn system, before the pain in her heart made it impossible for her to speak.

In an instant, cold sweat broke out on her forehead, and her face turned deathly pale.

Xu Qingzhu immediately came over and asked: "What's wrong with you?"

Liang Shi clutched her chest, "You... don't cry."

She was in so much pain that she trembled and couldn't say a complete sentence. Even when saying these few words, her teeth were chattering.

This was her first time experiencing this kind of pain—many times worse than when she'd cut her palm last time.

It was that feeling of knowing she was receiving punishment, but still being able to strongly sense that she was hovering on the edge of death.

Life hanging by a thread.

"Liang Shi, what's wrong with you?" Xu Qingzhu's voice was anxious: "I really didn't mean to scold you just now."

Liang Shi: "....."

But that damn system thinks you're dissatisfied with me.

[Ding dong ding dong! Emergency notice!]

That strange mechanical voice sounded again, carrying some urgency, speaking much faster than before. [Due to a detection error just now, the host suffered an undeserved disaster. The level two punishment from the misfortune system is now canceled.]

[We sincerely apologize, host. Because the system made announcements to you at inappropriate times, causing your misfortune points to accumulate too quickly, the Resentment Management Bureau³ will compensate for all errors caused. For the next thirty days, the misfortune system will suspend collection of your misfortune points and compensate you with five luck points.

Additionally, the time rewind function will be used to erase your target's memory of what just happened. You will return to the moment when you just got home. We hope the host will seize this opportunity and quickly accumulate luck points.]

[PS: To compensate for the harm you suffered, the Resentment Management Bureau will release management authority over you after you complete your mission.]

[Note: After you accumulate one hundred luck points, you will become the real Liang Shi and a truly free person.]

[Another PS: Due to the severity of this error, the Resentment Management Bureau will answer one question you pose. You may ask now or ask later. The question is valid for thirty days.]

[Note: If you ask now, the Resentment Management Bureau guarantees not to lie. We cannot guarantee this afterward.]

Liang Shi: "....."

If this system were a physical entity, she really wouldn't be able to control the knife in her hand.

However, after briefly weighing the pros and cons, Liang Shi chose without hesitation to ask her question now.

"Why did I come to this world? Did I originally come from this world?" Liang Shi asked the same question she had asked the system before.

She felt this question was crucial.

In the first half of her life, she had lost her memories from before age eight.

Her fear and suffocating feeling toward Mrs. Qi⁴ were too real, and she had always been someone whose intuition was quite accurate.

This time, her intuition didn't disappoint her either.

After a moment of silence, the system sighed in a human-like manner with that strange mechanical voice: [Yes, you came before, and your return is to fix an error committed by the God of Repair. That is all.]

Author Notes: (Translated from potential author commentary)

Footnotes:

¹ OOC: "Out of Character" - acting differently from the original character's established personality

² Happy old home: A euphemism referring to sending characters back to where they belong or their proper fate

³ Resentment Management Bureau: The governing body that oversees the transmigration/system management in this story universe

⁴ Mrs. Qi: Referring to Liang Shi's original adoptive mother from her past life, mentioned in earlier chapters as someone she feared

Chapter 44-2

Liang Shi let out a gentle breath.

If she had come before, that meant it was before she was eight years old.

So did the eight-year-old her exist in this world at the same time as the original owner?

Or did they switch places?

Both possibilities existed, but Liang Shi was more inclined toward the second possibility.

Had she come during some time period before age eight? Or had she originally been living in this world?

Liang Shi felt... this still needed further investigation.

However, now she knew that she couldn't reveal too much information about herself to Xu Qingzhu, especially the fact that she had transmigrated into a book. This would be considered cheating by the system.

But that picture was something Xu Qingzhu had discovered first. Would talking about things related to the picture while speaking from the original owner's perspective also count as self-exposure?

[Ding dong! Little System is back! Very sorry, host. Anything you do from the original owner's perspective doesn't count as self-exposure, but using this method to gain your target's trust counts as cheating. Your luck points accumulated fifteen points in an instant just now, so it was deemed a violation.]

[Due to the time rewind, your luck points have returned to their previous value. Please keep up the good work.]

[PS: You could speak more slowly, so you won't accumulate large amounts of luck points in a short period and be deemed in violation!]

Liang Shi: "....."

You're really a little genius.

But having just gone through such inhumane torture, Liang Shi didn't want to talk to it much.

The only thing she said was: "Why doesn't the Resentment Management Bureau punish you? You were clearly the one who disrupted order first."

The mechanical voice fell silent. After a moment, it mimicked humans' pitiful tone and said: [Wuu wuu, host, don't you like me anymore? I've already been so lenient with you, I've put all my tears into it!]

Liang Shi: "....."

Please just scram quickly, okay?

[Your insults have been received by Little System. After finishing talking with you, Little System will return to headquarters to receive punishment and replace the chip. Next, Little System's colleague will come to take care of you. You must work hard to complete your mission!]

Liang Shi: "....."

Nagged eight times a day.

Really!

Even office workers get vacation time! She worked twenty-four hours without rest and had to deal with punishments from time to time. How could one word describe such misery?

Liang Shi placated it, then the system quietly disappeared.

She came back to her senses and found herself and Xu Qingzhu standing at the entrance. She quickly opened the door.

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After that, everything proceeded the same as before, even the height at which Xu Qingzhu hung her coat was identical.

So time rewind wouldn't change anything.

After hearing Xu Qingzhu's words, Liang Shi still remained silent.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu and first poured her a glass of water, her voice gentle: "Drink some water first, let's talk slowly."

Yes, talk slowly so the luck points would accumulate more slowly.

Xu Qingzhu still looked tired. She took the water Liang Shi handed her and only took a light sip before placing the glass back on the coffee table.

Liang Shi said: "Wait for me to think about where to start with you, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her: "I already said, you don't need to think about how to make up lies to fool me. If you're willing to talk, I'll listen. If you're not willing, I'll go upstairs to sleep. I don't want to hear lies."

Liang Shi nodded: "I know. Don't get worked up first. I promise every word I tell you will be true, it's just that the story is very long."

"Then give me the short version," Xu Qingzhu said straightforwardly.

Liang Shi: "....."

"I need to organize my thoughts," Liang Shi said, pausing before asking: "Do you remember the phone call I had with my mom at the hospital?"

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment, then nodded.

That day, Liang Shi had questioned Qiu Zimin¹ about why she wanted to use her to make a deal with Zhou Yi'an.

Qiu Zimin's answer had been quite cutting too.

However, Xu Qingzhu's emotions had been very poor that day, so bad that she had almost wanted to ask Liang Shi for a hug.

She hadn't paid much attention to this matter. Every family had their own difficult scriptures to recite.

Especially in large families, enjoying privileges meant paying a price.

Families that sent their beloved daughters into arranged marriages were everywhere. The Liang family was simply no exception.

It wasn't anything special.

However, what puzzled her was why Qiu Zimin said that plot of land in the south of the city was especially important to the Liang family. What use would a company that made luxury goods have for a plot of land? How could it reach the point where not getting the land would mean bankruptcy?

During that period, Xu Qingzhu had so many messes of her own to deal with that she had no time to think about matters concerning Liang Shi, so she didn't investigate further. Thinking about it now, there were indeed many suspicious points.

"I remember some of it," Xu Qingzhu answered conservatively, though she actually remembered most of it.

This was probably the advantage of having a good memory.

"At that time, she wanted to introduce me to Zhou Yi'an, wanting to use me to exchange for that plot of land in the south of the city. She even wanted to encourage me to undergo differentiation surgery². To undergo secondary differentiation when I was perfectly healthy—this doesn't seem like something a mother would do, right?" Liang Shi spoke about this matter very calmly while also answering another question: "After waking up from the hospital, I lost many memories. You know that, right?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her: "So you have amnesia, not soul replacement? Are you certain?"

She restrained her gentle aura, and when she looked over intently, there was a somewhat oppressive feeling. Those clear eyes made one's heart involuntarily beat faster.

Liang Shi turned her face away and sighed lightly: "Can I remain silent on this question?"

Xu Qingzhu paused, then answered: "Yes."

"Because I myself have many questions that I haven't figured out yet," Liang Shi said. "As you said, I am free. I don't want to answer you with things I haven't figured out myself, which means I don't want to lie to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Alright."

"You went through my phone last time, didn't you?" Liang Shi asked her.

The strange image suddenly appeared in Xu Qingzhu's mind, instantly making her scalp tingle, but she still took a deep breath and said: "Yes, I apologize for that. It's because I wanted too much to know why you had changed like this."

"Is this version of me not good?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "Very good. But do you know how distressing it is for me to think every day about the question of who you really are?"

"I am Liang Shi," Liang Shi said with firm conviction and a smile. "I am Liang Shi. This is beyond doubt."

In her original world, she was also called Liang Shi.

Xu Qingzhu nodded, not dwelling on this question: "Continue."

"The bottom right corner of that photo said 'sacrifice,'" Liang Shi said. "I don't remember this incident, but I went back to the old mansion. Have you ever been in my room?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "After we got married, we moved to this villa. When I visited your home before marriage, I never spent the night there, and no one suggested you show me around your room."

Footnotes:

¹ Qiu Zimin: Liang Shi's adoptive mother in the Liang family

² Differentiation surgery: In ABO dynamics, a medical procedure to change one's secondary gender (Alpha, Beta, or Omega status)

Chapter 44-3

Generally speaking, before marriage, when a fiancée comes to the family home, she definitely should sit and look around in her partner's room. But Xu Qingzhu didn't—she just hurriedly ate lunch with Liang Shi, then Liang Shi hastily took her away.

They basically hadn't stayed for even two hours.

And Liang Shi seemed quite well-behaved in front of her parents, just maintaining constant vigilance.

Xu Qingzhu was generally quite accurate at reading people, so this was also what puzzled her.

Why would Liang Shi be so wary?

At that time they weren't married yet, and Liang Shi wasn't as much of a scumbag as she was after marriage. She had also tried asking, "Why are you afraid to bring me home?"

Liang Shi had answered then: "My parents are quite snobbish. They wanted me to marry Lin Xingcan, but I chose you, so I'm afraid they'll hurt you."

Xu Qingzhu had been moved by that answer for a long time.

Later she discovered it was just flowers in a mirror, moon in water—all illusion.

Now that Liang Shi brought up this question, Xu Qingzhu asked: "Is there a problem?"

"A big problem." Liang Shi closed her eyes and exhaled lightly. "The photo you saw on my phone that day was of my room. All the current layout is the same. When I went in, all I felt was oppression, discomfort, and fear."

"So I have reasonable suspicions." Liang Shi said: "I'm not the Liang family's biological daughter. My mother—perhaps I should call her Mrs. Liang—is using me to set up a scheme. Although I used to be a firm materialist and believed in science, I can't overcome some people's ignorance and superstition. I suspect I became a sacrifice and will be offered up."

Actually, she had another suspicion too.

But she didn't say it.

What if they said she was cheating again?

Someone as smart as Xu Qingzhu should be able to guess it too.

Just as Liang Shi finished thinking this, Xu Qingzhu said: "Is there a possibility that the ritual is fake, but wanting to destroy you is real?"

Liang Shi: "...!!!"

Indeed, talking to smart people didn't require much effort.

"To be honest, I've suspected before that you might be your father's illegitimate daughter from outside. Your family has four children—why does your mother treat only you differently? It's very simple to ruin a person: just have them listen to everything she says and prevent them from establishing correct values, and they'll be destroyed. And your former self clearly became such a person." Xu Qingzhu said: "But your mother isn't incapable of educating children. She taught Big Brother, Second Brother, and even Wanwan¹ very well."

Liang Shi's eyes lit up, but she couldn't show it too obviously, so she just said: "Right, I only recently figured this out too."

"So I followed the trail and traced it to Yunfeng Mountain." Liang Shi said: "It just so happened that our colleague mentioned going to Yunyin Taoist Temple this week to pray for peace talismans, so I went along. That Yunyin Taoist wasn't there, so I met another fortune teller."

Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu roughly what had happened at the temple today, omitting some content that would be troublesome for her.

As for Mrs. Qi², Liang Shi also told part of it, saying she occasionally had dreams where Mrs. Qi beat her childhood self, and that Qi Jiao was also beaten together with her, but she couldn't remember anything else.

She told Xu Qingzhu most of the story, and after understanding everything, Xu Qingzhu stared at her for a while, then patted her shoulder: "It's okay, things will get better."

Liang Shi: "....."

Was this supposed to be comfort?

Neither Liang Shi nor Xu Qingzhu wanted to open that photo again to look at it, so they spared themselves.

As for the ritual matter, they would need to ask more people and consult professionals. For now, they were also at an impasse.

But it wasn't really an urgent matter.

Liang Shi handed over the peace talisman she had obtained for her. Xu Qingzhu held it in her hand and weighed it.

Then she smiled: "Very thoughtful of you."

"I really did go to pray for peace talismans." Liang Shi said: "Asking about those things was incidental. After all, those things are in the past for me. Even if I remember them, it would just add to my troubles."

"So what if I knew the truth? Wouldn't life still have to go on as usual? But when I had my fortune told today, the person said I have a blood disaster coming."

"How serious a blood disaster?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "Not clear, the person didn't say."

"Then be careful recently." Xu Qingzhu said: "Wear the peace talisman."

"Didn't you never believe in these things?" Liang Shi smiled: "Science student."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After saying all this, their atmosphere returned to its usual state.

Even a bit closer than before.

Night fell, dusk gathered, and evening shadows hung low.

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu what she wanted for dinner. Xu Qingzhu shook her head and said she didn't particularly want anything.

So after thinking, Liang Shi asked if she wanted to eat cake?

Xu Qingzhu: ".....That works too."

Making desserts was quite troublesome, but Liang Shi did it with ease.

Xu Qingzhu helped out in the kitchen.

Though she couldn't really help much, in this kind of busyness, both of them relaxed.

No longer thinking about those complicated matters.

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Meanwhile, in another corner of China, Taoyuan County, Taozhi Village.

The courtyard was muddy after the recent rain, and having just finished funeral arrangements, the entire yard was deathly quiet.

A girl in a blue sweater came in from outside, calling loudly: "Xinran³, are you home?"

The girl who was stroking a golden pixiu⁴ in her hand looked up: "I'm here."

The girl brought in a bowl of rice: "My mom said you'd be scared alone at night, so she sent me to keep you company. Also, you haven't eaten all day, so my mom made this for you."

"No need." Guo Xinran said: "Please thank Auntie for me. I'm fine alone, I just want some quiet."

The girl was still worried: "Really? At least take the food."

Guo Xinran smiled: "Alright."

This smile seemed rather forced to the girl.

Then the girl sighed: "So what will you do? Are you going to look for your biological parents?"

Guo Xinran nodded: "I should. All these years, I never knew I was picked up⁵."

"If your family could leave you such precious gold items, they must be wealthy people." The girl said sincerely: "If you find your biological parents, life will definitely be better than now."

Seeing her low spirits, the girl said a few more words before leaving. Before going, she repeatedly reminded her not to be sad, and if she got scared at night, to call out and she would definitely come keep her company.

Guo Xinran smiled and said nothing more.

After the girl left, Guo Xinran's expression changed. She got up and poured that bowl of mixed vegetables straight into the chicken coop, looking with disgust at everything in the courtyard.

The light in the yard was dim. She stared at the dark, looming rooftop and thought to herself: "Finally dead."

Now she could go look for her biological parents.

Footnotes:

¹ Wanwan: Liang Shi's younger sister in the Liang family

² Mrs. Qi: The woman from Liang Shi's traumatic childhood memories, her original adoptive mother

³ Xinran: A common Chinese female name, meaning "joyful"

⁴ Pixiu: A mythical Chinese creature believed to bring wealth and ward off evil spirits; golden pixiu jewelry is considered very auspicious and valuable

⁵ Picked up: Chinese euphemism for "adopted," often used when referring to abandoned children who were found and raised by others